Pre-Jamming

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Before we dive into the technicalities of nodes, signals, and state machines, we must first establish a **technical baseline**. Game development is a multidisciplinary field that requires a synthesis of software engineering, mathematics, and creative design. As seniors, you already possess a robust toolkit from previous courses. This activity serves to audit that toolkit and align your ambitions with the reality of the semester.

The Pitch

During our first meeting, every student will be given **5 to 10 minutes** to present their developer profile. Think of this as your elevator pitch to the studio where you want to get hired. You are expected to answer the following:

1. **The Past:** What is the most complex software system you have built to date? This does not have to be a game (e.g., a CMSC 22 project, a web app, or a data structure implementation), but **games are preferred**. In any case, what were the primary architectural challenges you faced?

2. **The Future:** If scope, time, and budget were non-factors, what is the dream game you want to build? Briefly describe the core mechanical and gameplay loop.

3. **The Reality:** Considering we only have one semester, what is a **feasible** version of that dream? What would make it publishable and be worthy of a **1.0 grade**?

Interactive Format

As the class is interactive, each student is expected and encouraged to ask questions or provide feedback for each presenter. Use this time to identify potential collaborators.

Prep

You are not required to bring a formal slide deck, but you are **highly encouraged** to bring visual or auditory aids, as a projector will be provided. This includes:

- Screenshots or video captures of previous projects
- A mood board or reference images for the game you intend to develop
- A GitHub link to a repository you are particularly proud of
- Demonstration of a game you already built, if possible

Common Pitfalls

Avoid:

- Vague descriptions (“I want to make an RPG”)
- Unrealistic scope (“I want to make the next Elden Ring”)
- No understanding of technical limitations

Instead, demonstrate:

- Specific mechanical vision (“Roguelike w/ Pokemon mechanics, wink wink hehe”)
- Awareness of scope (“Core game loop first, polish later”)
- Technical feasibility analysis

Objective

The goal of pre-jamming is twofold:

1. Gauge Collective Technical Experience

This allows tailoring the difficulty of machine problems and pacing through the syllabus based on the class’ demonstrated capabilities.

2. Facilitate Partner Formation

Since all major projects are done in pairs, use this time to identify peers whose:

- **Interests align:** Similar genre preferences or game design philosophies
- **Skills complement:** Systems programmer + UI designer, mathematician + creative designer
- **Work ethic matches:** Similar expectations for commitment and quality

Partner Selection Strategy

Look for complementary strengths, not identical skill sets. The best pairs combine different perspectives: algorithmic thinkers with creative designers, optimization experts with UX specialists.

Deadline

By the next session, all pairs must be submitted to the instructor. If you cannot find a partner, please inform the instructor immediately. GLHF!

This activity is to be accomplished in class.